

Apple isn't tracking every move you make, in fact, it might very well be that the location of every Internet connected person on this Earth can be mapped in real-time. Why doesn't that work on the battlefield? Well, ever tried connecting to the Internet in the middle of Afghanistan? In Siberia? In the middle of the Sahara dessert? That's the digital divide that military is desperately trying to bridge.

One way they're doing this, a system that was first introduced in the now defunct Land Warrior program, is by adorning their soldiers with an assortment of radios (WiFi and otherwise) that would generate a sort of Personal Area Network (PAN) that would keep, say, a platoon connected with each other. Even if one platoon member carries a more powerful radio, he can communicate with his commanding officers. It's a simple and elegant way of keeping in touch with your troops, though slightly expensive.

BIOMETRIC SENSORS

A no-brainer in games and sci-fi movies, biometric sensors are to be incorporated into soldiers' gear, allowing battlefield commanders, medics, psychiatrists and mad scientists alike can monitor the status of the troops on the field. Everything from a sudden onset of stress and anxiety to a downed soldier, and even the precise nature of the wound is what these embedded sensors hope to keep track of. Coupled with the PAN, this means precise, up-to-date information for, at the very least, your platoon mates.

CLIMATE CONTROL

One of the things that's drilled into a soldier's head is that he must remain cool under fire. The pentagon aims to ensure

that the soldier is exactly that regardless of the situation by incorporating a Microclimate cooling system within an experimental bio-suit that they're hoping to implement sometime in the near future. It's said to provide up to 100 watts of heating or cooling as required.

EYES AND EARS

A soldier has a lot to keep him occupied in combat, equipment to manage, his sector

camera-equipped platform that the soldier can access. Perfect for giving an overview of the battlefield.

As you can see in the image below, the soldier is actually commanding a drone via an Xbox 360 controller and observing the surroundings with his helmet mounted HUD.

Another interesting module that is supposed to be incorporated into a soldier's gear is supposed to be a very precise



Spot the odd one out here. HINT: Someone's not playing by the rules

to cover and his buddies to be aware of. The latest generation of smart helmets aim to take care of all that. Other than accomplishing the obvious, which is protecting a soldier's head from shrapnel and gunfire, the next generation head-gear will work as armour as well as a fully functional computer. An eye-piece will work as a HUD, providing the soldier with all the data he needs just a few centimetres from his face. As a bonus, the eye-piece will also be able to stream data from any UAV/

directional microphone. The directional nature of the device will mean that soldiers can get precise, real-time updates as to the direction of all incoming fire, much like the indicators present in a game such as Call of Duty.

As you can see, there are a lot of exciting new toys in store for the future soldier. Too many for us to cover here, but if you want to know more, head over to <http://dgit.in/FutureForce> for more information. It makes for an interesting read. 

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